

of Nations that would maintain peace and security in the world. At the Yalta Conference in February 1945, Roosevelt, Churchill, and Russian premier Joseph Stalin agreed to the establishment of the United Nations and affirmed that it would meet for the first time in San Francisco in April.

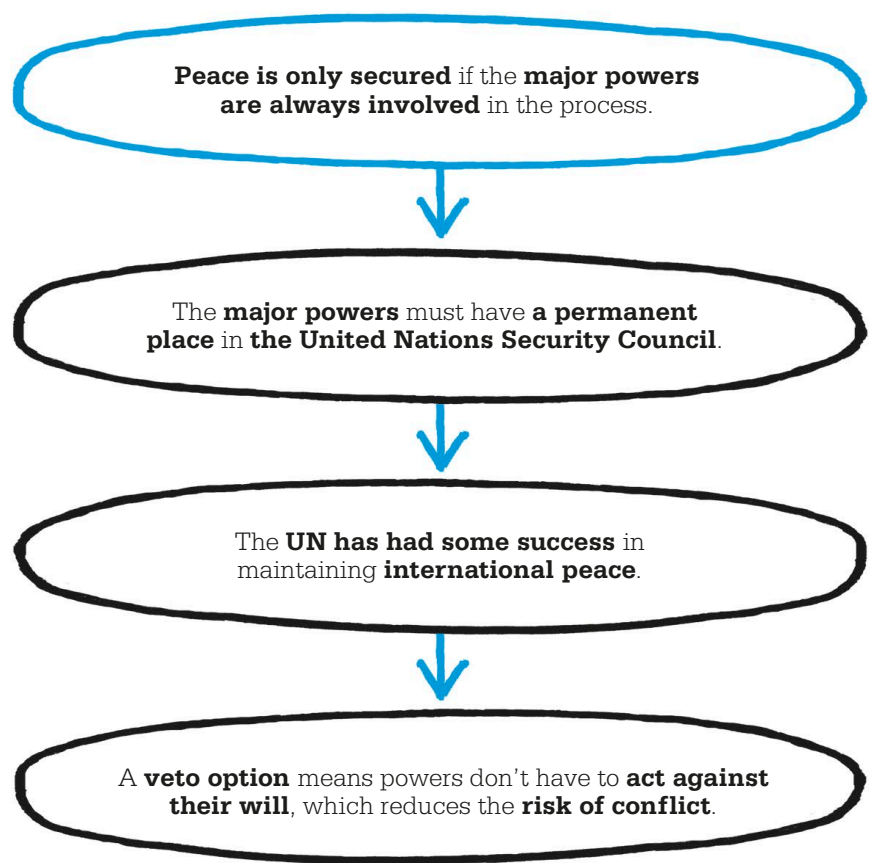
The UN inherited several structures from the League of Nations, including the Secretariat, the departments led by the UN secretary general that would carry out the organization's basic administration. But there were two crucial additions: the General Assembly and the Security Council.

The General Assembly

Although it has no actual power, the General Assembly is the UN's parliament, where members meet to discuss important issues and make recommendations, so it has considerable influence. Each of the 193 members is represented and has one vote. There are also nonmembers such as the Vatican and Palestine, which can participate but have only observer status.

Most ordinary decisions depend on a simple majority vote. But some—such as the admission of new members, budgetary matters, and peace and security issues—require a two-thirds majority. Because of the assembly's large size, voting often tends to be in blocs—five groups of member states that are put together on a regional and geopolitical basis. The General Assembly meets once a year and also has special sessions, such as electing a new president for the year from each bloc.

The main session opens each year with a general debate, where members can raise concerns. But most of the assembly's work is done in the six committees:



Disarmament and International Security (also known as the First Committee); Economic and Financial; Social, Humanitarian, and Cultural; Special Political and Decolonization; Administrative and Budgetary; and Legal.

The Security Council

In many ways, the real power of the UN lies with the Security Council. The original idea behind the Security Council was that the "big four" powers—the United States, Britain, the Soviet Union (USSR), and China, later joined by France—would be permanent members and steer all major decisions. Initially, they were joined by six nonpermanent members, each serving for 2 years. An

amendment to the UN Charter in 1965 added a further four nonpermanent members, boosting membership of the Security Council to 15.

Generally speaking, the nonpermanent members are selected in a bid to represent the different geographic regions fairly, with five members coming from Africa or Asia, one from Eastern Europe, two from Latin America, and two from western Europe or other areas. The membership continually rotates, with five of the 10 nonpermanent members being elected each year by the General Assembly for 2-year terms, and with five retiring. The presidency is also rotated, each member standing for 1 month at a time. »